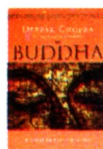


Emperor's New Clothes

A racy, fictionalised recreation of the Buddha's life which falls into the new-age bestseller trap



BUDDHA: A STORY OF ENLIGHTENMENT
by DEEPAK CHOPRA
HarperCollins
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■ By Rajiv Mehrotra

Deepak Chopra has written a provocative "reimagining" of what life might really have been like for the young Siddhartha on his journey to becoming the Buddha. This is a racy, insightful, fictionalised account with evocative cinematic images and juxtapositions. Chopra's Buddha is conceived not immaculately by the queen, but while she urges her husband, "Don't make love to me like a king. Make love like a God". Contemporary Buddhists are at pains to emphasise that the Buddha was a human being like any of us. Despite a life of luxury and comfort, driven by the need to find a way out of suffering, not just for himself but for others, he set out to find the insights and techniques that would liberate him and all of us from the inevitable pain of birth, sickness and death. His was a human effort that any of us can replicate. We learn from the Buddha, we are inspired by him, but the effort must be our own. We need to verify the Buddha's teachings by our own experience and understanding. We are encouraged to evolve our own unique paths if our insights appear at odds with those of the great teacher. The Buddha gave diverse teachings that often appeared contradictory, positioned as they were to respond to the diverse capacities and mental dispositions of those who he taught.

The young Prince Siddhartha that Chopra has recreated is a real person with real-life experiences that shape his character and personality. When he leaves the palace for

the forest we can appreciate why. The promptings that lead him to do so have resonances in our own time. Much of this emerges from Siddhartha's struggles to resist the efforts of his powerful father to mould him in his own image so that he becomes king of the material world, rather than that of the spiritual, as had been foretold.

Chopra skillfully reworks the legend of the demon Mara who appears dramatically in the traditional legend to tempt the Buddha into the pleasures of *samsara* (material world) as he sits under the bodhi tree on the brink of enlightenment. Mara, for Chopra, is the Buddha's shadow, the inner demons he wrestles with throughout his life.

The story falters once Siddhartha leaves the palace and formally begins his quest. There are few convincing psychological insights into how and why the young Siddhartha as he evolved into the Buddha arrived at the unique truths that liberated him from the suffering of suffering. If these were not cataclysmic revelations under the bodhi tree, what were the elements of

his psychological experiences, the elements of his *sadhanas* that came together and led him to the four noble truths? What was the achievement of his own enlightenment, and its implications for the Buddha? Here the book seems to give up. Perhaps this is asking too much from popular literature.

Chopra candidly acknowledges he didn't waste his time with scholarship, of which in fact little exists, especially about the young Siddhartha. He did read the definitive and scholarly *Buddha* by Karen Armstrong and Thich Nath Han's *Old Path White Clouds*—both enduring classics, but his story is not about Buddha Dharma per se, for that there is only a brief epilogue—"A Practical Guide to Buddhism". The author instead says he researched *Google*, visited places of Buddhist pilgrimage and drew on folklore he grew up with, to evolve a basic structure within which he juggles history, myth and legend with contemporary psychology and the commercial imperatives of selling a book, to effortlessly chalk yet one more success for himself on the best sellers list. There is a sprinkling of sex and violence to help it on its way.

While purist Buddhist scholars are likely to treat his most recent effort with disdain, it will be a mistake. It is true, we can never really know if the book is "psychologically" true as Chopra asks us to accept but none of this diminishes the importance of its contribution to spiritual storytelling or prevents it from finding an enduring place in any serious library. The book nudges us into going beyond traditional hagiographic accounts, stimulating us into a better, deeper understanding of the psychological processes and motivations that lead a young aspirant born into a life of privilege and opportunity to give it up for an uncertain spiritual quest. His story could be ours. ■



Illustration by RAM